Lesson 1.5: Practitioner Notes

Common Roadblocks & How to Overcome Them

Executive Summary

- Initial challenges, especially increased daytime sleepiness, are a normal and temporary part of implementing Sleep Restriction Therapy (SRT).
- Anticipating and preparing for common roadblocks (e.g., anxiety about rules, breaking the schedule) increases long-term adherence and success.
- The core principle for overcoming setbacks is self-compassion combined with a swift return to the established routine, focusing on the "next right choice."

Clinical Insights

Why this matters for mental health: The "all-or-nothing" thinking common in anxiety and depression can lead patients to abandon beneficial treatments after a single perceived failure. Normalizing setbacks is a key therapeutic intervention. This lesson models cognitive reframing by labeling challenges as "roadblocks" (solvable problems) instead of "failures" (character flaws).

Connection to sleep disorders: This addresses the concept of "treatment adherence," a primary factor in the success of CBT-I. The initial fatigue from SRT is known as a potential barrier to completion; proactively addressing it here is critical. This is also where sleep-related performance anxiety is first directly confronted.

Evidence-based research summary:

1. Research consistently shows that while SRT is highly effective, initial daytime sleepiness is a common side effect that can impact adherence if not properly managed through patient education (Perlis, M. L., et al., 2011).
2. Studies on habit formation emphasize the importance of consistency over intensity. The "focus on one thing" strategy is based on behavioral principles of simplifying a target behavior to increase the likelihood of success (Gardner, B., et al., 2012).
3. The concept of self-compassion has been shown to be a significant factor in maintaining health behavior changes, as it mitigates the negative effects of guilt and self-criticism following a lapse (Sirois, F. M., 2015).

Quick Reference Guide: Troubleshooting Common Issues

Roadblock	Core Strategy	What to Do
"I feel more tired."	**Trust the Process**	Acknowledge this is normal. Remind yourself it's a sign of building sleep pressure. Stick to your wake-up time above all else. This feeling typically improves in 7-10 days.
"My mind is still racing."	**Contain the Worry**	Dedicate 15 minutes in the early evening to a "Worry Journal." If thoughts arise in bed, gently tell yourself, "I'll address you tomorrow at my scheduled time."